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Introduction and Communication

Read the scenario below and answer the following questions.

Project Communication Dilemma: Orion Tech's Struggle

Orion Tech, a mid-sized software company, launched a new project to develop a mobile app for a healthcare client. The app aimed to connect patients with doctors remotely, track appointments, and securely store medical data.

At the start, the project team was highly skilled, but communication quickly became a major issue:

- Developers were unclear on specific project requirements, leading to repeated rework.
- The project manager relied mainly on **emails** to communicate, which overwhelmed the team and caused important updates to be missed.
- Stakeholders complained they were not receiving **status reports** on progress, costs, and risks.
- During meetings, some team members dominated discussions while others stayed silent, leading to **selective listening** and critical misunderstandings.
- Cultural differences between the local team and offshore developers created misinterpretations in tone and urgency.

As a result, deadlines slipped, the budget increased, and client satisfaction dropped. Orion's leadership is now questioning whether the project manager followed effective **communication protocols** and whether stronger planning tools (such as a communication plan, feedback loops, and performance reporting) should have been in place.

Answer the following questions:

- 1- Was the project manager at fault for relying mainly on email instead of using multiple communication methods (verbal, written, formal, informal)? Why or why not?

Yes. Effective communication in projects requires a balance of formal (reports, documentation) and informal (meetings, conversations) methods. Relying solely on email caused information overload and reduced opportunities for clarification and feedback.

- 2- Should Orion Tech have implemented a **formal communication plan** at the start of the project? What elements should it have included?

Absolutely. A communication plan should have identified:

- Stakeholders and their information needs
- Types of reports (status, cost, risk, performance)
- Frequency and methods of communication (meetings, dashboards, reports)
- Feedback loops to confirm message understanding

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- 3- How might **active listening** and **effective listening techniques** have improved team collaboration?

Active listening (paraphrasing, clarifying questions, confirming understanding) would have prevented selective listening. Encouraging full participation would ensure quieter members' perspectives were included, reducing errors caused by incomplete communication.

- 4- In what ways could cultural and language differences have been better managed to reduce misunderstandings?

The project manager could have:

- Used plain language and avoided idioms
- Implemented cross-cultural awareness training
- Used video conferencing to enhance tone and context
- Confirmed understanding through feedback and summaries

- 5- Was it reasonable for stakeholders to expect **regular performance reports** (status, progress, forecasting)? Why are these critical?

Yes. Stakeholders fund and approve the project; they need visibility into progress, risks, and costs. Performance reports provide transparency, accountability, and early warning of deviations from the plan.

- 6- Could stronger leadership during project meetings have prevented selective attention and bias? Provide an example.

Yes. The project manager should have facilitated discussions by inviting input from all members, using structured agendas, and summarizing key points. For example, asking offshore developers to present their weekly updates would balance participation and ensure no group dominated.

- 7- If you were the project manager, how would you redesign the communication system (tools, reporting, meetings) to prevent such issues in future projects?

I would:

- Develop a formal communication plan before launch
- Use a mix of tools: email (records), Teams/Slack (quick updates), dashboards (visual tracking), and video calls (collaboration)
- Schedule regular status meetings with agendas and action items
- Provide stakeholders with weekly progress reports
- Create clear feedback loops so all team members confirm understanding of requirements